

UPS

With the power situation in India showing no signs of improving, it's the UPS market that's getting better! The UPS (Uninterruptible Power Supply) provides a PC with a grace power backup time in which open applications can be saved and closed and the PC shut down normally. More home users than ever before are investing in UPSes.

While there are many different types of UPSes, the common ones are Standby UPSes, which become operational in the event of a power failure; Online UPSes, which power the PC all the time; and Line-interactive UPSes, which are the same as Standby UPSes, but which provide limited voltage regulation.

Questions to ask the dealer

Does the UPS feature any sort of voltage regulation?

Some UPSes come with AVR (Automatic Voltage Regulation), which reduces the damage caused by brownouts. A brownout is a period when the electrical voltage is reduced below normal level—you see this when the lights get dim.

Does the UPS feature modem and surge protection?

Most UPSes—but not all—come with modem and power surge protection, which can be a lifesaver for your PC in extreme scenarios such as thunderstorms.

What kind of warranty does the dealer provide?

You should look for an on-site warranty for the UPS, since the UPS is likely to be heavy. Similarly, look for UPSes from manufacturers that provide a support number and have a good support network.

Does the UPS produce a sine wave output?

Generally, cheaper UPSes produce a square wave output, and those producing a sine wave are more expensive. A sine wave UPS is much more efficient than the square wave type, and the power it supplies is closer to normal AC power.

Does it have a manual bypass switch?

With a bypass switch, the UPS allow will pass power to through it to your equipment if it is broken or being serviced. This

reduces PC downtime while the UPS is dysfunctional.

Usage Tips

❑ Periodically check the UPS by deliberately stopping the power supply.

❑ Completely discharge the batteries about once a month—this enhances the



life of the batteries and increases the time for which they stay On when powering the PC.

❑ The monitoring software that comes bundled with the UPS can automatically shut down the PC when there's a power failure and the battery charge becomes critically low.

❑ Do not overload the UPS by connecting equipment such as laser printers which draw heavy power, unless the manufacturer has specified that you can do this.

❑ Don't subject the UPS to temperature or humidity extremes, dust, or static electricity. Keep the area around the UPS clean.

❑ Make sure the UPS is properly earthed all times.

❑ Never mix new and old UPS batteries. This will cause more power to be drawn from the new battery, and will reduce its life.

❑ Sealed Lead Acid batteries contain live electrical current and can be extremely dangerous. When changing the UPS battery, never touch the battery terminals directly or with metal objects! ■

Points To Ponder

What type of UPS do I need?

A Standby UPS is the most commonly available type. This type of UPS charges when the AC power supply is on, and springs into action in the event of a power failure.

The issue here is that when the power goes out, the switch to battery power happens almost instantly, but not quite; and though it's rare, there's a chance that the switching might not be fast enough, in which case the PC could get reset. An Online UPS powers the PC all the time, even when AC power is on, and so doesn't do any switching when the power goes off. It charges on the AC power.

A Standby UPS is less expensive, and is preferred by home users. Corporations prefer the more reliable Online UPSes.

How should I decide on the power rating of the UPS?

To decide on the power or VA rating of the UPS, you need to take into account the power rating of your PC's power supply, the size of the monitor, and any extra accessories connected to the PC that you may want the UPS to power. As a simple rule, multiply the power rating of your PC's power supply in watts by 1.4, and add it to the product of the volt and ampere ratings of the monitor, to decide on the power rating of the UPS.

For home use, how long should the UPS battery backup last?

The UPS battery backup time should be at least 10 minutes, so you can save your work and properly shut down the PC in case of a blackout.